University of St.Gallen

8,196: Research Seminar Financial Institutions

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Contents

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Paper

The research paper

- An empirical banking research paper contains the following sections:

  1. Introduction 2 pages
  2. (Optional) Conceptual framework
  3. (Optional) Institutional background
  4. Data & methodology 4/5
  5. Main results 4/5
  6. (Optional) Extensions to main findings 1
  7. Conclusions 0.5

Tables can be in text or at the end,
but they count toward our 15pp limit.
Robustness / extension tables can go in appendix
(and don't count)

Introduction

- First section to read, **last section to write**
- Elements:
  1. What is the precise research question?
     - Should be stated very early in the introduction (first/second paragraph)
     - Golden rule: One paper, one question
  2. Motivation: Why is this question important?
     - Economic theory
     - Policy relevance
  3. How do the authors answer the question; what are the findings?
     - Brief preview of methods (identification strategy) and main results
  4. How does the paper contribute to the literature?
     - What have others done? Select the 2/3 most closely related papers
     - What gap in the literature does the paper fill?

Conceptual framework

- This section develops the main hypotheses that are to be tested in the data
- It should describe the theoretical framework (economic theories) or the economic intuition supporting the link between the main variable of interest (x) and the outcome variable (y)
- Can be used to specify the main hypotheses (for example, the expected signs of the coefficients in a regression of y on x)
- It is optional as a standalone section – but the main hypotheses and their **theoretical or empirical motivation should be included** somewhere in the paper
- It is useful to think about this framework early in the research process, as it will be very helpful to structure the analysis and define the methodology

Institutional framework

- Optional section
- Explain institutional details relevant for the research question or research design (when this is not straightforward / common knowledge)
- Examples:
  - Background leading to introduction of a new regulation (Was it unexpected?; Who is the treated group?)
  - Institutional setting in the country / region under investigation
  - External validity considerations
- If not too complex, can be incorporated in data section

Data & methodology / 1

- Explain what are the main data sources and the main steps in the data cleaning process (see published papers as reference)
- Provide a description of the final dataset:
  - Level of observation (bank-years, household cross section, firm-bank pairs, loan-bank-firm-year, transaction,...)
  - Time frame (e.g. 2010–2024) and frequency of observations
  - Explain which observations were excluded (why) and which adjustments done
  - Discuss main strengths and weaknesses of the data
- Introduce the main variables used in the analysis
  - Outcome variable(s), main independent variables of interest
  - Provide variable definitions
  - Provide basic summary statistics

1–2 paragraphs

Data & methodology / 2

- Key consideration: What is the main **source of variation** of interest?
- Present preliminary relationships between main variables of interest (univariate analysis)
  - Trends, bar chart, box-and-whiskers
  - Scatterplot, correlations
  - Cross tabulations, t-tests of mean differences
- Describe the methodology employed in the analysis
  - Write down the estimation equation
  - Discuss estimation method (OLS, IV, Diff-in-diff...)
  - Introduce control variables and main variation exploited in the analysis
  - Discuss identification issues (omitted variable bias, simultaneity, selection bias, ...). **Address** them or (at the minimum) discuss how they could be addressed.

IV and Diff in Diff not expected

Results 1/2

- Present the main results
  - Headline results usually contained in a single (main) table
  - Discuss sign, magnitude, statistical and economic significance of main coefficient(s) of interest
  - Focus is on main coefficient(s) of interest; control variables only briefly discussed

Results 2/2

- Discuss the main results
  - Discuss strengths and weaknesses of methodology (threats to identification)
  - Provide an interpretation of the results
  - Provide additional analyses (tables) to support main findings / interpretation
    - How robust are the results to the assumptions?
    - Alternative outcome variables, explanatory variables, controls,...
    - Alternative estimation method(s)
    - Keep this short – are main results confirmed?
    - Robustness tables can be placed in an appendix

Extensions

- Optional section
- Discuss implications of the findings or other extensions
  - Which mechanisms drive the observed results?
  - Discuss (test for) potential alternative stories leading to similar results
  - Are there other consequences of the main findings? (economic consequences, policy implications)
  - Additional analyses can be placed in tables in the appendix
- Not essential for a mini research paper, increasingly required for journal papers

Conclusions

Keep very brief

- Summarize the main results
  - Restate the research question
  - Summarize the answer to the question
- Discuss the relevance of the findings for
  - Policy (lessons learnt)
  - Theory (confirm / reject)
- Discuss the limitations of the analysis (internal validity)
- Can the findings be generalized (external validity)

Overall content considerations

- **Focus** your paper.
  - Broader research questions can involve several aspects that are often correlated (e.g. "culture" embodies social and moral values, language, hierarchies, time preferences ...)
  - Pick one specific aspect (e.g. time preferences) and make this the focus of your paper
- **Motivate** your paper.
  - Why is the research question interesting?
  - Remember this is a research seminar in financial institutions.
- Consider the **economic** significance of results
  - Coefficient magnitudes determine if the question is of economic relevance
- **Discuss** potential shortcomings of empirical approach
  - Data limitations, internal validity, external validity
  - How could these be improved in future work?

Writing considerations

- Use an active voice throughout the paper ("we construct our dataset [...]" rather than "the dataset is constructed [...]")
- Be concise (e.g. "we cleaned the data" rather than "we exported the data to Excel to correct spelling mistakes in the countries' names")...

  ... but report all relevant steps that could affect results (e.g. sample selection, winsorization)
- Footnotes are useful to disclose information that is slightly less relevant, but they should be used sparingly
- AI tools can be used to support your research

  ... but they need to be fully acknowledged in accordance to the regulations

Presentation

The presentation

- Presentations usually structured as followed:
  1. Research question and the motivation for the study
  2. Preview of methodology and main findings
  3. (Optional) Contribution to the literature
  4. Data and methodology (details)
  5. Main results and discussion
  6. (Optional) Extensions
  7. Conclusions
- For longer presentations you can provide more details in 4 and 5

Some pointers

- Golden rule: Less is more
  - Slides should not be overfull
  - Respect the time limit (rule of thumb: **1 slide = 2/3 minutes**)
  - Skip non-essential slides if you are running out of time
  - It's a good idea to use hyperlinks for backup material and go through them only if time permits
- Use big, readable fonts (including tables and figures)
- Use colors with high contrast (i.e. avoid yellow)
- Unlike a written paper, it is OK to repeat
- Practice many times before!

Overfull slide

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Small fonts

This is a presentation,

not a sight test!!

If the text is too small,

people will have to squint

... and they will lose interest!

Discussion

The discussion / 1

- Research question:
  - Is it well defined? Is it well motivated?
- Analysis:
  - Is the methodology clear? Is it suitable to answer the RQ?
  - Are the data adequate? Have they been correctly processed? Are the variables adequate?
  - Do conclusions follow from the analysis?
  - Is the interpretation of the results correct? Are there any alternative interpretations?
  - Are the limitations of the analysis acknowledged? Are there further limitations?

The discussion / 2

- Contribution
  - What do we learn from the results (theory, policy, other)?
- Other
  - Is the paper (presentation) well written (clear)? Well structured?
- Papers will be available for students to read before the discussion if needed
- **We expect all students and presenters to actively participate in the discussion**

Some pointers

- No paper is perfect
  - but we can still learn from them
  - research is about accumulating many (small or large) contributions
- Try to be constructive
  - What alternative analysis could be done to support the interpretation?
  - What alternative data could be added to complement the results?
- Be kind